

menziesii), and the pale green blooms of *Nicotiana langsdorffii*.

To provide a foil for the flowers, consider the wealth of foliage plants available. These include the vast variety of coleus (*Solenostemon*) with their multicolored leaves, the bright silver foliage of *Senecio cineraria*, and the dark purple-lobed leaves of *Ipomoea batatas* 'Blackie'.

Design options

Annuals and biennials provide an extended season of color in formal schemes, and are particularly useful for filling beds and gaps in borders. In addition, they can be used to edge flower beds and borders or to create Victorian-style bedding schemes, which are enjoying renewed popularity.

Hardy annuals, such as cornflowers (*Centaurea*), poppies, and California bluebell (*Phacelia campanularia*) are ideal for naturalistic or wildlife schemes. For mixed schemes, grow them in containers like half-hardy annuals or buy plug plants and set them between more permanent perennials and shrubs (many annual seeds will not germinate in these situations because of competition from neighboring plants).

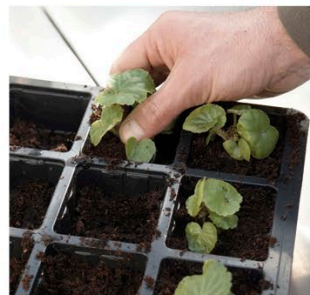
Annuals and bedding plants make striking features in seasonal containers, window boxes, and hanging baskets. Use feature plants, such as fuchsias, zinnias, and begonias in the center, together with trailers like *Helichrysum petiolatum* or trailing petunias to soften the edges of your pots. In fall and winter displays,

POTTING PLUG PLANTS

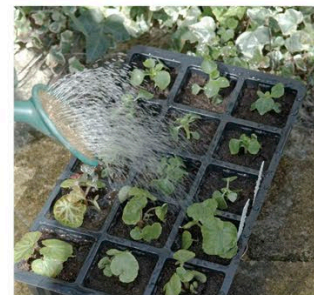
If you do not have the space or time to sow seeds, look for seedlings, known as "plugs." Many popular plants, including busy Lizzies, begonias, lobelias, and fuchsias are available in this form, with the largest choice available from mail-order specialists. Pot small plug plants and grow them indoors until the frosts have passed.



1 Remove plugs
Water the plugs as soon as they arrive. Fill large modular trays or 3in (8cm) pots with good-quality potting mix designed for seedlings. Use the blunt end of a pencil to gently push them out of their original containers from the bottom.



2 Plant up modules
Make a hole in the compost with your finger or the pencil and insert a plug into each module or pot. Firm the compost around the plants with your fingers, ensuring there are no air gaps, and taking care not to compact the soil or damage the roots.



3 Water the plants
Using a watering can with a fine spray, water the plugs well. Keep them in a cool, light, frost-free place, and keep them well watered. Harden off the young plants before planting them outside after the risk of frost has passed.

combine dwarf conifers, such as *Juniperus communis* 'Compressa', with dainty violas.

Year-round color

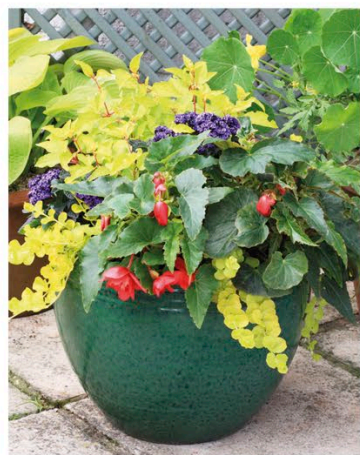
The long flowering season of annuals and biennials provides months of color. Violas flower in winter but put on their best show in spring, when they are joined by forget-me-nots (*Myosotis*) and wallflowers (*Erysimum cheiri*), which look particularly

beautiful when combined with bulbs such as daffodils and tulips. Follow these with any of the summer annuals and biennials, such as foxgloves (*Digitalis*). Busy lizzies (*Impatiens*) are particularly useful for shady sites. Fall stars include Chinese asters (*Callistephus chinensis*) and, in warm climes, the fruits of *Solanum pseudocapsicum* will brighten a winter's day. In cold areas, bring these bushy evergreens indoors.

SOWING SEEDS IN TRAYS

Growing summer bedding plants from seeds can be very cost-effective, especially if you have several containers or beds to fill. Sowing seed in trays indoors is the ideal option for half-hardy or frost-tender plants, allowing you to start them off early in spring so that plants are mature

and ready to flower when planted outside. Small seeds, such as petunias, are difficult to space evenly in trays; seedlings will need to be transplanted when they have a few leaves to larger trays, pots, or modules. Seed specialists offer a huge variety of plants via mail order or online.



Pot of seed-sown annuals



1 Fill seed trays
Using good-quality seed compost, fill some clean seed trays to within 1in (2cm) of the top. Gently press another seed tray on top to level out and firm the surface. Using a watering can with a fine spray, water the compost and allow to drain.



2 Sow seeds
Pour some seeds into your hand and carefully space them out on the compost surface. Sprinkle sieved compost over the seeds, and cover to the depth specified on the seed packet. Also check the seeds' required germination temperature.



3 Cover and keep moist
Label the seed tray, and cover with a lid or a clear plastic bag. Place in a light spot. Keep the soil moist, and remove the lid or plastic bag as soon as the seedlings emerge. Harden them off before planting the seedlings outside.